Timeline: The Course of Cultures in Ancient Tamilagam		
Culture	**Time Period**	**Cultural Traits**
Paleolithic Period	Circa. 20,00,000 years to circa. 8,000 BC (BCE)	Hand axes, cleavers Hunting and gathering
Mesolithic Period	Circa. 8,000 years to circa. 1,300 BC (BCE)	Microlithic tools Hunting of animals and birds Gathering of plant food No knowledge of metal
Neolithic Period	Circa. 2,000 BC (BCE) to 1,000 BC (BCE)	Polished Stone Axes Microliths Domestication of animals Cultivation of crops Multiplicity of groups Co-existence of hunter-gatherers and pastoral groups
Iron Age	Circa. 1,300 BC (BCE) to 300 BC (BCE)	Megalithic burial custom Co-existence of hunter-gatherers and pastoral groups Development of chiefdom Knowledge of iron, black and red ware, black ware ceramics Craft specialisation, specialised groups: potters, blacksmiths
Early Historic and Sangam Age	300 BC (BCE) to 300 AD (CE)	Cultural traits of Iron age Monarchies of Chera, Chola and Pandya Development of hero worship Poetic traditions and literature Trade and exchange by sea

clay. Evidence of Neolithic village is found at Payyampalli in Vellore district and a few sites in the Dharmapuri region.



Neolithic people perhaps devised the first pottery. They made pottery, using a slow wheel called turn-table or made pottery out of hand. Before firing, the pottery was polished with pebbles. This process is known as burnishing.

Payyampalli is a village in Vellore district of Tamil Nadu. The earliest evidence for the domestication of animals and cultivation of plants is found at this site, which was excavated by the Archaeological Survey of India. Evidence for pottery making and cultivation of horse gram and green gram has been found in this village.

Iron Age/Megalithic period

The **cultural period** that succeeded the Neolithic is called the Iron Age. As the name suggests, people used iron technology. It preceded the Sangam Age. The Iron Age was a formative period and the foundation for the Sangam Age was laid in this time. During the Iron Age, many parts of Tamil Nadu were occupied by people. An exchange relationship developed among the people.

The people of this age had knowledge of metallurgy and pottery making. They used iron and bronze objects and gold ornaments.

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